



ROHIT PANSARE



KeM

1. *A fabric on display by Rajasthan's Bindaas Unlimited*

2. *A training centre run by the Jan Swasthya Sahyog in Chhattisgarh*

3. *Posters by Karwan-e-Mohabbat in Delhi*

AGAINST THE DOWNWARD SPIRAL OF PUBLIC LIFE AND THE DISTRESS OF THE MARGINALISED, THESE GROUPS ARE A SILVER LINING

costs. In Bilaspur, Chhattisgarh, **Jan Swasthya Sahyog** (**JSS**) offers succour to Adivasis who shuffle between an uncaring government system and ruthless private practitioners. The JSS is not a charity; it doesn't dole out band-aids. Instead, it focuses on the rights of Adivasis to good nutrition and health by delivering services that address their priorities. The JSS also trains villagers to be health workers for their community, providing practical skills where they are most needed, reducing their reliance on undependable others.

Most of us wouldn't know about these efforts if it weren't for the **People's Archive of Rural India** (**PARI**), that extraordinary repository of reportage and cultural chronicles by students and professional journalists across the country. Here are stories in vivid words and pictures of every aspect of rural reality. They describe the harshness of caste, class and gender, but also the wondrous, the joyful, and the absurd.

Another initiative that I love for how it tackles a serious subject—sexuality—with sass is **Agents of Ishq**. Its non-preachy, playful tone never gives way to boredom or condescension, deftly tackling the taboo around conversations on sex, love and desire.

Speaking of love, I must salute **Karwan-e-Mohabbat** (**KeM**), a Delhi-based initiative that journeys to places where communal violence has broken people's lives. This motley group has dedicated itself to listening to others' pain. When the politics of hate has divided communities, Karwan reminds us that there are still others who care. With beautifully crafted short films that bring alive the spirit of the Indian Constitution, KeM drives home its message about the enduring ties that connect all Indians.

It takes a special kind of integrity and grit to dedicate oneself to the task of creating a country where everyone can lead a life of dignity and purpose, where we protect the earth that nurtures us, and cultivate our astonishingly rich cultural and ecological diversity. Extraordinary people spurred the 10 groups in this essay. But, like Gandhi, it is their ability to inspire thousands of seemingly ordinary people to greatness that has effected change. ■